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Case Study

Computer Forensics

Summary

The report we are going to present contains the findings of our digital forensic examination of a disk image of a laptop belonging to Jean, the Chief Financial Officer of M57.biz, following the unauthorized disclosure of a confidential employee salary spreadsheet on a competitor's website. The examination was requested by M57.biz's first-round funder and sought to determine:

1. When did Jean create this spreadsheet?
2. How did it get from her computer to the competitor's website?
3. Who else from the company is involved?

The leak of data, especially sensitive data, is a serious matter that not only affects trust within the company but also with clients and can bring about significant financial repercussions “Financial impacts vary by region, with European organizations facing GDPR penalties of up to €20 million or 4% of global turnover, while US companies experience an average cost of $9.44 million per breach (IBM Security, 2024).” (Thorpe-Smith, 2025)

Body of Report

2.1 Evidence examined

Item	Description
Disk image	Forensic image of Jean's laptop hard drive
Spreadsheet copy	Copy of leaked employee salary spreadsheet provided by client
Email artifacts	Email messages recovered from Jean's laptop via Autopsy
Document metadata	Embedded Office properties — Author, Last Saved By, timestamps

Forensic tool	Autopsy Digital Forensics Platform

Methodology

- Received and verified integrity of the disk image of Jean's laptop.
- Loaded disk image into Autopsy and ran full ingest modules including file metadata extraction, keyword search, email parsing, web artifact recovery, and device connection logging.
- Located the salary spreadsheet and extracted all metadata including filesystem timestamps and embedded Office document properties.
- Examined all recovered email messages, identifying the full communication chain between Jean and Alison Smith across both of Alison's email accounts.
- Searched for web history, browser artifacts, USB device connections, and any additional indicators of exfiltration from Jean's laptop.
- Conducted keyword searches for all identified parties including alison@m57.biz, alex@m57.biz, and tuckgorge@email.com.

2.3 Spreadsheet metadata

Field	Value	Significance
File created	July 19, 2008 — 13:28:03 GMT-12	Same day as Alison's follow-up email

Document author	Alison Smith	Alison had prior involvement with the original file
Last saved by	Jean User	Jean was last to modify and save on her laptop

2.4 Email communication chain

#	Date	From → To	Content	Significance
1	Jul 7, 2008	alison@ → jean@	Requests names, salaries, SSNs for all employees and potential hires	Alison initiates scheme — contradicts her interview
2	Jul 19, 2008	alison@ → jean@	"This VC guy is being very insistent; can you please send me..."	Pressure via false pretense

3	Jul 19, 2008	jean@ → alison@	"I have attached the information you have requested." [Spreadsheet attached]	Jean acts in good faith
4	Jul 19, 2008	alex@ → jean@	Response to Jean from Alison's secondary account	Alison operating fake second identity
5	Jul 19, 2008	jean@ → alex@	"Which email should I forward it to?"	Jean genuinely confused — supports innocence
6	Jul 19, 2008	alex@ → jean@	Directs Jean to alex@ address. CC: alison@. tuckgorge@email.com in thread.	Alison monitoring both accounts
7	Jul 19, 2008	jean@ → reply	"I am confused"	Confirms Jean did not understand the scheme
8	Jul 19, 2008	alison@ → jean@	"Thanks again Jean, I will handle from here, and again please don't tell anyone about this. Please stop this email train."	**Critical consciousness of guilt, evidence suppression**

2.5 The alex@m57.biz account

No employee named Alex exists at M57.biz. But after doing some investigation we found out and confirmed that alex@m57.biz was another email address for Alison Smith herself. She emailed Jean from both accounts simultaneously, with alison@m57.biz cc'd on all alex@m57.biz messages.

2.6 **The tuckgorge@email.com address**

tuckgorge@email.com is an unidentified email address that was part of the email threads, and obviously an outsider judging the Gmail account appurtenance. This address requires investigation beyond the scope of this examination.

2.7 Jean's device

- no evidence of further distribution
- No emails from Jean to any competitor, unknown party, or tuckgorge@email.com were found.
- No evidence of file upload to any external service was identified

2.8 Interviews summary

Alison (President):

- *I don't know what Jean is talking about.*
- *I never asked Jean for the spreadsheet.*
- *I never received the spreadsheet by email.*

Jean (CFO):

- *Alison asked me to prepare the spreadsheet as part of new funding round.*
- *Alison asked me to send the spreadsheet to her by email.*
- *That's all I know.*

2.9 Timeline of events

July 7, 2008: Alison emails Jean requesting names, salaries, and SSNs for all employees and potential hires.
July 19, 2008: Alison sends follow-up email referencing an "insistent VC contact" to pressure Jean.
July 19: Jean creates the salary spreadsheet on her laptop.
July 19: Jean emails the spreadsheet to alison@m57.biz — "I have attached the information you have requested."
July 19: alex@m57.biz (Alison's secondary account) responds. tuckgorge@email.com appears in thread.
July 19: Jean: "Which email should I forward to?" / "I am confused" — genuine confusion confirmed.
July 19: Alison: "Thanks again... I will handle from here... please don't tell anyone... please stop this email train.
Spreadsheet appears on competitor website.

Conclusion

1. When did Jean create this spreadsheet?

   Jean created the salary spreadsheet on **July 19, 2008, at 13:28:03 GMT-12:00** after a request from Alison Smith.

2. How did it get from her computer to competitor's website?

   Jean emailed the spreadsheet to Alison Smith at alison@m57.biz on July 19, 2008. No evidence of further distribution exists on Jean's laptop. After receiving the file, Alison was

also operating under another account: alex@m57.biz. Another email tuckgorge@email.com was in the email thread and after receiving the email, Alison stated she would "handle it from here." Alison then deliberately terminated the email chain to suppress the evidence trail. The posting to the competitor website is attributable to **Alison's actions** after the file left Jean's laptop.

3. Who else from the company is involved?

Alison Smith, President of M57.biz

References:

Labs, S. K. (n.d.). *Autopsy.* Retrieved from sleuthkit.org: https://www.sleuthkit.org/autopsy/

Thorpe-Smith, J. (2025, April 29). *Data Leaks: The Biggest Risks, Consequences, Causes & How to Prevent Them.* Retrieved from metomic.io: https://www.metomic.io/resource-centre/what-are-the-biggest-risks-of-data-leaks

Autopsy Digital Forensics Platform. (2008). The Sleuth Kit. Retrieved from https://www.autopsy.com

Glossary:

Autopsy:

“Autopsy® is a digital forensics platform and graphical interface to The Sleuth Kit® and other digital forensics tools. It is used by law enforcement, military, and corporate examiners to investigate what happened on a computer” (Labs)

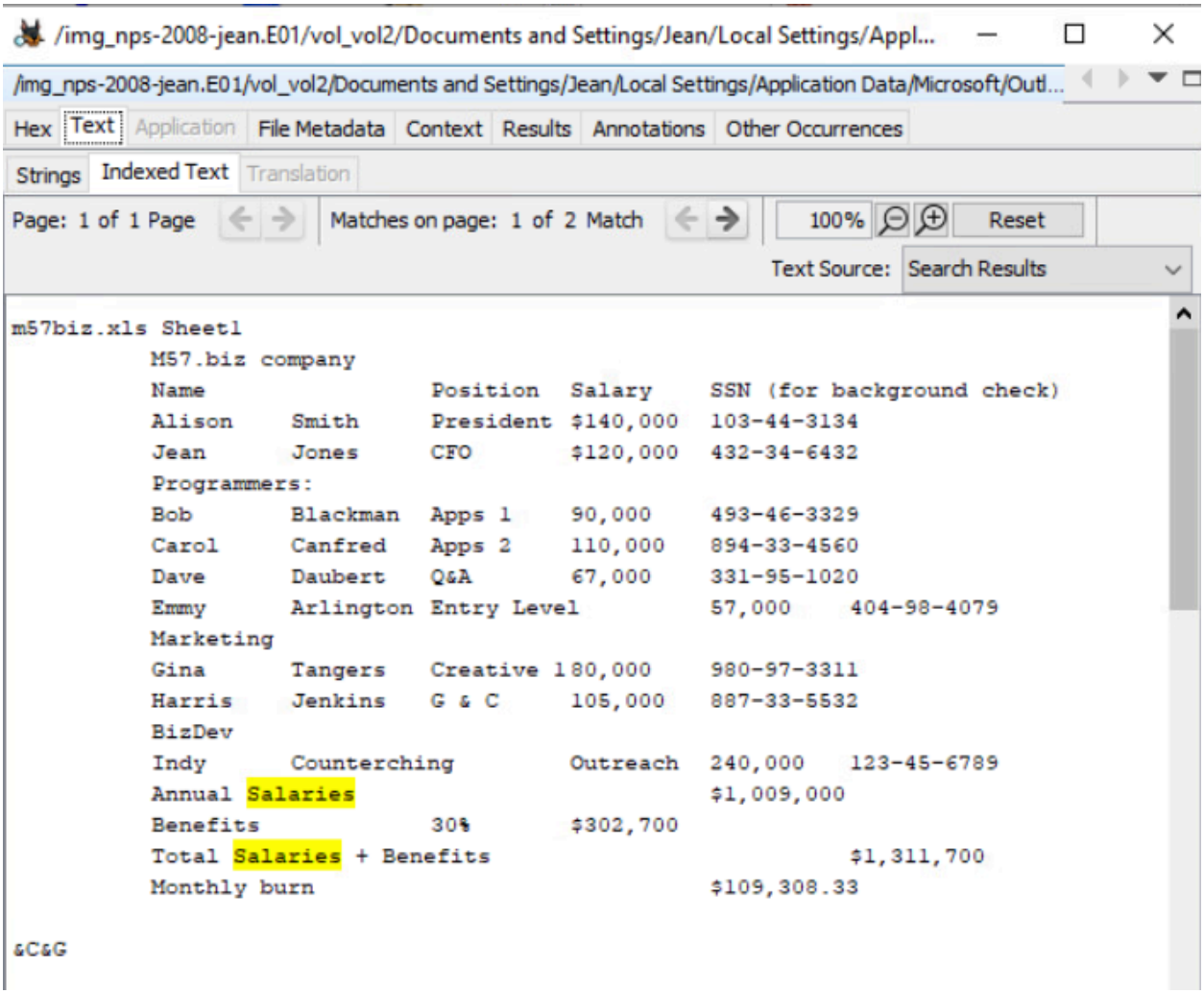
Disk image

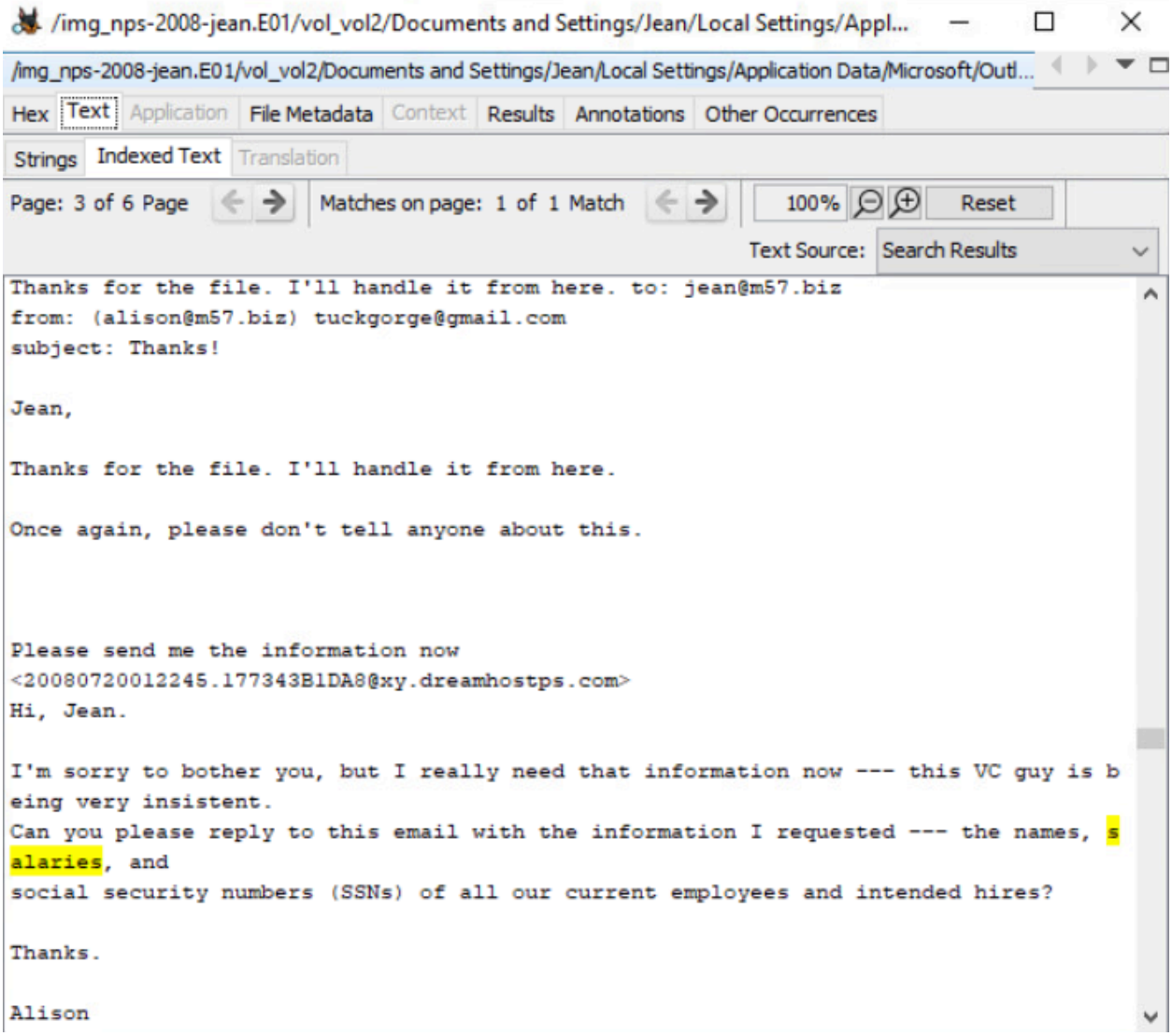
A bit-for-bit forensic copy of a hard drive, usually taken from concerned individuals' laptops, preserving all data, including deleted files, in a format that can be analyzed without altering the original evidence.

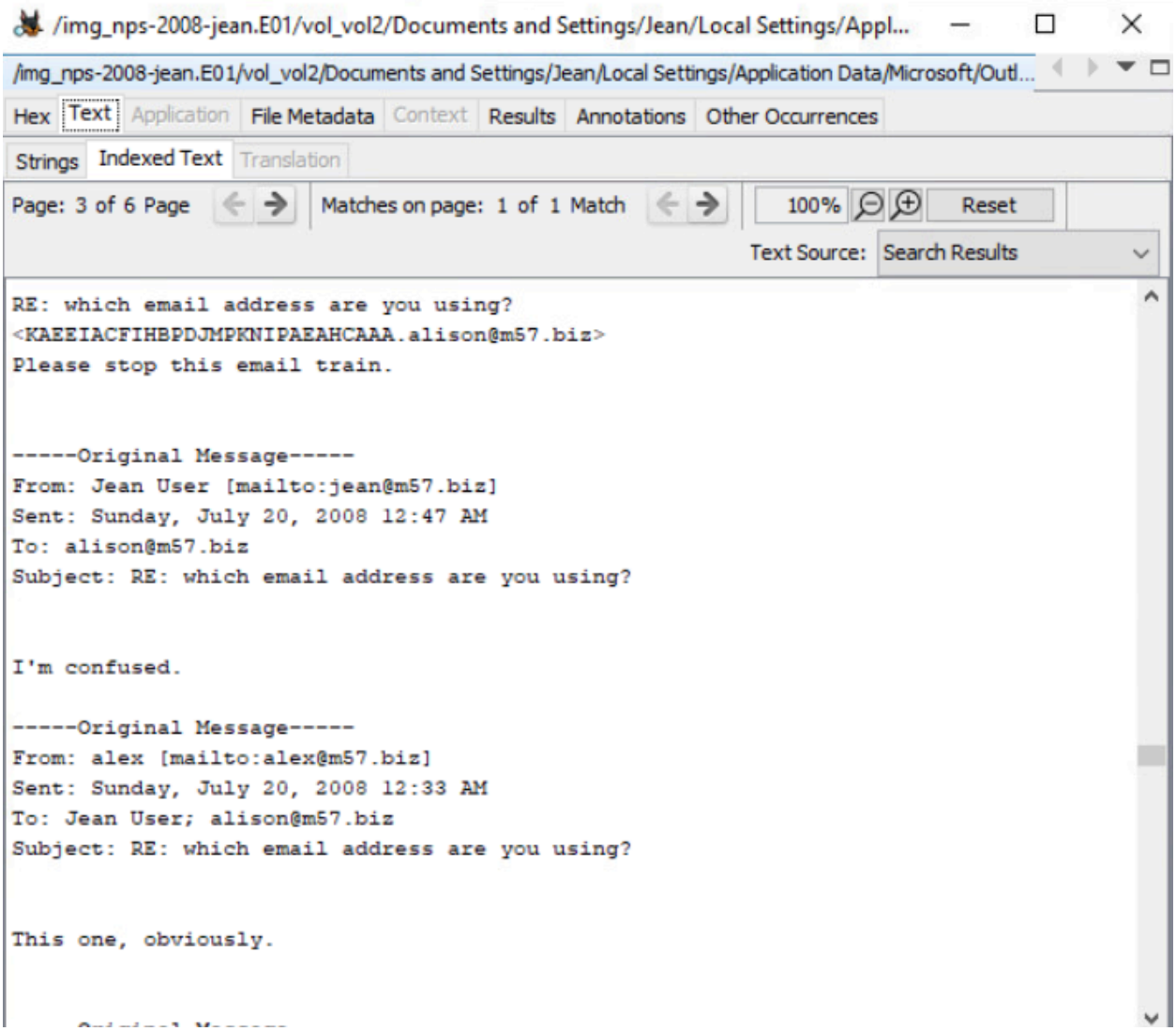
Timestamp

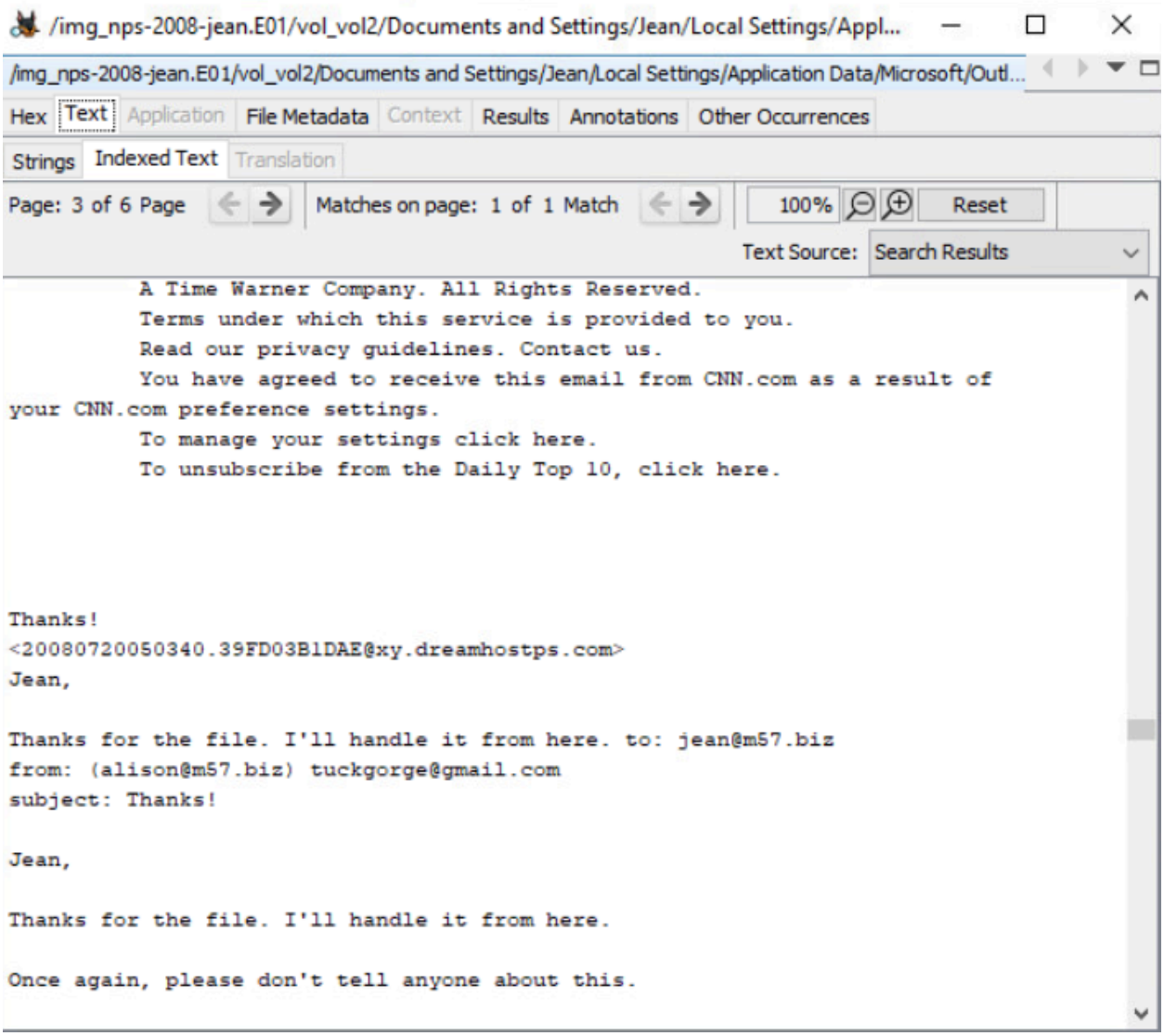
A recorded date and time associated with a file event, including creation, modification, and last accessed.

Appendixes:




/img_nps-2008-jean.E01/vol_vol2/Documents and Settings/Jean/Local Settings/Appl...
/img_nps-2008-jean.E01/vol_vol2/Documents and Settings/Jean/Local Settings/Application Data/Microsoft/Outl...
Hex
Text
Application
File Metadata
Context
Results
Annotations
Other Occurrences
Strings
Indexed Text
Translation
Page: 3 of 6 Page
Matches on page: 1 of 1 Match
100%
Reset
Text Source:
Search Results
Thanks for the file. I'll handle it from here. to: jean@m57.biz
from: (alison@m57.biz) tuckgorge@gmail.com
subject: Thanks!
Jean,
Thanks for the file. I'll handle it from here.
Once again, please don't tell anyone about this.
Please send me the information now
<20080720012245.177343B1DA8@xy.dreamhostps.com>
Hi, Jean.
I'm sorry to bother you, but I really need that information now --- this VC guy is being very insistent.
Can you please reply to this email with the information I requested --- the names, salaries, and
social security numbers (SSNs) of all our current employees and intended hires?
Thanks.
Alison


/img_nps-2008-jean.E01/vol_vol2/Documents and Settings/Jean/Local Settings/Appl...
/img_nps-2008-jean.E01/vol_vol2/Documents and Settings/Jean/Local Settings/Application Data/Microsoft/Outl...
Hex
Text
Application
File Metadata
Context
Results
Annotations
Other Occurrences
Strings
Indexed Text
Translation
Page: 3 of 6 Page
Matches on page: 1 of 1 Match
100%
Reset
Text Source:
Search Results
RE: which email address are you using?
<KAEEIACFIHBPDJMPKNIPAEAHCAAA.alison@m57.biz>
Please stop this email train.
-----Original Message-----
From: Jean User [mailto:jean@m57.biz]
Sent: Sunday, July 20, 2008 12:47 AM
To: alison@m57.biz
Subject: RE: which email address are you using?
I'm confused.
-----Original Message-----
From: alex [mailto:alex@m57.biz]
Sent: Sunday, July 20, 2008 12:33 AM
To: Jean User; alison@m57.biz
Subject: RE: which email address are you using?
This one, obviously.


/img_nps-2008-jean.E01/vol_vol2/Documents and Settings/Jean/Local Settings/Appl...
/img_nps-2008-jean.E01/vol_vol2/Documents and Settings/Jean/Local Settings/Application Data/Microsoft/Outl...
Hex
Text
Application
File Metadata
Context
Results
Annotations
Other Occurrences
Strings
Indexed Text
Translation
Page: 3 of 6 Page
Matches on page: 1 of 1 Match
100%
Reset
Text Source:
Search Results
A Time Warner Company. All Rights Reserved.
Terms under which this service is provided to you.
Read our privacy guidelines. Contact us.
You have agreed to receive this email from CNN.com as a result of
your CNN.com preference settings.
To manage your settings click here.
To unsubscribe from the Daily Top 10, click here.
Thanks!
<20080720050340.39FD03B1DAE@xy.dreamhostps.com>
Jean,
Thanks for the file. I'll handle it from here. to: jean@m57.biz
from: (alison@m57.biz) tuckgorge@gmail.com
subject: Thanks!
Jean,
Thanks for the file. I'll handle it from here.
Once again, please don't tell anyone about this.